

COVID-CON 2020

COVID-19 HAS DECIMATED INDUSTRIES, SEPARATED PEOPLE FROM THEIR LOVED ONES AND RENDERED MANY FOLK

WITHOUT EMPLOYMENT. On the flip side, the lockdown measures put in place to deal with the pandemic have been a boon for many upcoming startups which were focused on hyperlocal delivery services. Folks have been cooped up in their homes for far too long and as a result have discovered new activities to pass time, some of which have been productive while others have been quite worse.

The conspiracy theorists have been having a field day. A global event such as the Covid-19 pandemic has presented the same premise as most of the apocalyptic scenarios straight out of their conspiracy theories. And with a lot of free time at hand, these conspiracy theorists who were stuck in their little echo chambers have clambered out of their little comfort-zones to find and form even larger communities. As a result, the sheer amount of misinformation going about has grown to be of great concern.

Having the misfortune of having to travel to office for a few days in September, I ended up engaging in a few conversations with many cab drivers and others. A few things seem to have stood out in my conversations with the average joe. The first being that a lot of the government's efforts into educating its citizens about Covid-19 and the precautionary measures to be taken have borne fruit. The second was that the oddest conspiracy theories have taken root in some of the most unexpected individuals.

Imagine sitting in the backseat of a cab and the driver suddenly brings up a WhatsApp forward about 5G towers being linked to the spread of Covid-19. For starters, the two are in vastly different domains of science and linking them in a chain of causality takes a special type of creativity. What's even more surprising is that such a nonsensical theory would spread thousands of kilometers away from where they'd originated and find a few believers. I did my part in letting the cabbie know that there are no 5G towers in India and yet we happen to have one of the largest Covid-19 infected populations in the world and we're growing

at a ridiculous pace. I also pointed out that countries like South Korea which adopted 5G quite early have one of the least infected populations in the world. I don't know whether I had any impact on the cabbie's mind. Perhaps he no longer believes in the stupid theory or perhaps, in his mind, I'm too far gone to see the "real truth".

On the other side of the world, we're seeing mass gatherings of folks who believe that Covid-19 is a globalist hoax and that the virus was purposefully spread in order for billionaires to implant the masses with microchips during the testing or vaccination phase. And that once everyone is microchipped, some nefarious machinations will be set in motion. A quick game you can play is to type Coronavirus or Covid-19 in Google followed by some ridiculous outcome and count the number of search results. "Coronavirus microchip" results in 3.86 million results and "Coronavirus mind control" nets you 587 million results. The Internet is a fun place if you can decipher and gather information from reputed sources but it can be equally destructive if you click through the first link and believe everything that's written over there.

The most recent video to go viral on the topic happens to be an eight-year old video that's spreading on Facebook about a certain "project engineer who actually worked on the microchip" in question who is warning people to not get vaccinated as the microchip is the "mark of the beast". The silliness of such a claim might be readily apparent to most folks reading this page but do remember that there are a few that'll believe in this misinformation. While I don't see it becoming a huge problem, it does evoke a bit of concern. Perhaps the Government might need to step up its efforts of stemming the flow of such misinformation. We know that the folks over at Facebook certainly need to ensure that this garbage doesn't spread any further. So do me a favour and strike up a conversation with folks around you and do your part in quelling the misinformation. We already have our hands full with an actual problem, let's not wait for the conspiracy theories to spread any further. 



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